The main difference between the BJP and the Congress was about a political mindset that combined digital with offline campaigning. ‘The Congress is still in the old traditional campaigning mindset,’ says Jairam Ramesh. ‘They don’t realise that there has been a generational shift. They don’t realise that the population has become much more connected and much more urban. It is a mindset issue. If you WhatsApp or email any senior Congress leader, you are unlikely to get any response, but if you do it in the BJP, chances of getting a response are pretty bright.’

‘Our mindset was still traditional, our resources were limited,’ he says. ‘That got reflected in our social media campaign. We had a good campaign in terms of substance. Whether we were able to get it out is a question. Our manifesto is a good example. We had a better manifesto than the BJP, but the outreach of that manifesto was pretty poor. We weren’t able to get it out enough. This has always been one of the weaknesses as far as the Congress is concerned. Compared to 2014, in 2019, we were better. We have to look at it in comparison to what we were doing in the past. Compared to what our competition was doing, we fell short, but compared to what we were doing, it has been a remarkable transformation.’

Jairam showed me WhatsApp pictures of Congress workers protesting in the Northeast. ‘For example, in the last five minutes,’ he says, ‘I am getting images of our workers who are agitating outside the RBI office in Agartala on the economic slowdown and they are putting it on Facebook. This is something that was unheard of even two-three years ago and is not something that is being done centrally. It is being done by our people in Agartala.’

Is that not part of the problem? That the Congress has often seen social media as something external to it, whereas for most public institutions and consumers, digital platforms are intrinsic to what they stand for. ‘I am not defending the disparity that exists,’ he says. ‘We have a lot of catching up to do.’[46]

The BJP’s Batman vs the Congress’s Bhakt ka Chashma